

When did you first get interested in the stock market?

My father invested in stocks. As a young boy I saw my father check the stock quote page of the paper every day. I was curious what he was doing, so I asked him about it. I think I bought my first stocks when I was nine years old.

How does a nine-year-old have money to buy stocks?

I had a paper route. One of my parents opened a custodian account for me.

Did your father help you pick stocks to buy?

No, he gave me an S&P stock guide. I leafed through it and found two local companies I recognized—Wheeling Pittsburgh Steel and McCrory, which was a five and dime chain store—so I bought them. Both companies eventually went bankrupt. I made a little money on Wheeling Pittsburgh Steel, but I held McCrory into bankruptcy.

My father was a product of the Depression, and he was scared to death of being poor again. Somehow—I don't know how he did it—he transferred that insecurity to me. From a very early age, I knew I wanted to be financially independent. That was very important to me. I remember when I was a freshman in college, I put together a 30-year financial plan outlining how I could save and invest my money. I calculated that by saving two-thirds of my income and earning 10 percent a year on my investments, I could be a millionaire by the time I was 53. The reason I picked chemical engineering was that I was good at math and chemistry, and engineering paid well. It was as simple as that. My whole goal was to make \$12,000 a year. I almost switched to business several times during college.

Why didn't you?

I came from a family with a science background. My father was a veterinarian, one of his brothers was a heart surgeon, and the other brother was an engineer. It was sort of expected that I would major in science or engineering. Business was considered too easy. But I wasn't a very good engineer. I did well academically because I was dedicated and worked extremely hard. My father also scared me to death about how